The CareLeaders Learning

Course brochure

Words that matter

A guide to good recording

Someone is going to read this.

Training and a workbook for anyone who writes about children known to children's social care, so records are accurate, useful and written with the child in mind. Built around four activities people do first on their own, then at their table.



Length
From 90 minutes to a full day

How
Face to face or workshop or keynote

Group
From one team to a whole conference

For
Social care and fostering and more

The problem it solves

Records are read later: by the next worker, at review, by inspectors and often by the child. Weak case notes mix fact with opinion, hide the reasoning behind decisions and label rather than describe. Audits pick it up, and so do children reading their files.

Helps with

- Recording and the words we use
- Getting ready for inspection



What is different after the course.

For your staff

- Separate fact, observation and opinion, and show their reasoning in records
- Build chronologies the next worker and the next review can use
- Write case notes as if the child will read them
- Describe rather than label when writing about a child

For children

- Records they could read and recognise themselves in
- Clear, written reasons for the decisions made about their lives
- Language that describes them, not labels that follow them

What they learn

The knowledge and the tools.

- What makes a good record and what makes a poor one
- Recording models, and why we recommend Writing to the Child
- How to separate fact, observation and opinion and show your reasoning
- How to build a chronology people can use
- Language that describes rather than labels

Who it is for

- Social workers and team managers
- Early help and family support workers
- Fostering and adoption staff, including supervising social workers
- Personal advisers and leaving care staff
- Business support and anyone else who writes in a child's record

Session by session

How the course runs.

 Story  Theory  Action

1 Review a case note

Spot what is good, poor or missing in a real, anonymised case note, and what a child reading it in ten years would make of it.

You leave with A shared view of what makes a good record and a poor one

2 Read the story

What do I think, why, and what should I do? Analysis before action: separating what you saw from what you think, showing your reasoning and recording decisions.

You leave with A way to separate fact, observation and opinion in your notes

3 Build a chronology

Turn a story into a clear chronology: what goes in, what stays out, significant events, keeping it current and how it reads at the next review.

You leave with A chronology the next worker and the next review can use

4 Write to the child

Writing to the Child, the recommended model. The same case note, rewritten for the person it is about, using language that describes rather than labels.

You leave with One record rewritten to the child, to take back to your team

Choose how you run it

Formats.

Face to face

We come to you: development days, twilights and team days, in your building or a venue you choose.

Length	A 90-minute team session to half a day
Group	One team, or staff from across a service
You provide	A room, a screen and the time protected

Workshop or keynote

A shorter, high-energy version for conferences, staff briefings and board sessions.

Length	A full conference day: a keynote and workshops
Group	A whole workforce
You provide	The slot in your event, a screen and a microphone



Included: A workbook for every participant, with one section made local to your procedures

Delivered Delivered as a conference day for Devon in September 2026, with a workbook for every delegate.

Do people work on real case notes?

Yes. Bring real, anonymised case notes. Each activity is done on your own first, then discussed at your table, and everyone rewrites one record to the child before they leave.

Can it respond to what our audits are finding?

Yes. One section of the workbook is written for your own procedures and audit findings, and we give your practice leads a short summary of what the room said.

Is this only for social workers?

No. Anyone who writes in a child's record, including early help, fostering, adoption and business support staff.

How long is it?

From a 90-minute team session to a full conference day. The four activities scale to fit.

Can you make it specific to us?

Yes. One section of the workbook is written for your own procedures and audit findings.

Why Writing to the Child?

Because records are read by the child, often years later. Writing to them produces records that are accurate, respectful and clear about why decisions were made.

Can our staff run it again?

Yes. We can hand over the slides and facilitator notes.

Can you shape it around our service?

Yes. We tailor the examples, the length and the mix of people in the room to your service, your procedures and the children you work with.



Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Who designs and delivers it

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19, and has spent his career since inside children's services as a consultant, trainer, speaker and national engagement lead.

He set up The Care Leaders to go from care leaver to care leader, and to help others make the same move. He led the national engagement on England's new fostering standards, was a Knowledge Equity Fellow at Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, and was awarded the British Empire Medal in 2018.

Every course is designed by Luke and follows the same Story, Theory, Action approach. It is delivered by people with lived experience of care and professional experience of children's services.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford
- **45+ keynotes since 2024**
  From team days to national conferences

The CareLeaders Learning

Getting started

Bring a guide to good recording to your team.

1 **Get in touch**
Tell us who it is for and roughly how many people.

2 **Have a call**
We talk through your service, your people and your dates.

3 **Get a clear quote**
We quote per cohort, based on numbers, format and how much tailoring you want.

4 **We run it**
Shaped around your service, your procedures and the children you work with.

hello@thecareleaders.com

Often booked with

Words that matter
From Case Note to Letter
Rewriting records as if the child will read them, because one day they might.

Words that matter
Language that Lifts
The words we use about children in care, and the ones that help them feel like children.

Words that matter
Profiles that Find the Right Home
Writing and reading referrals and profiles that give children the best chance of the right match.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.